CONSTITUENCY WATCH

MUMBAI NORTH

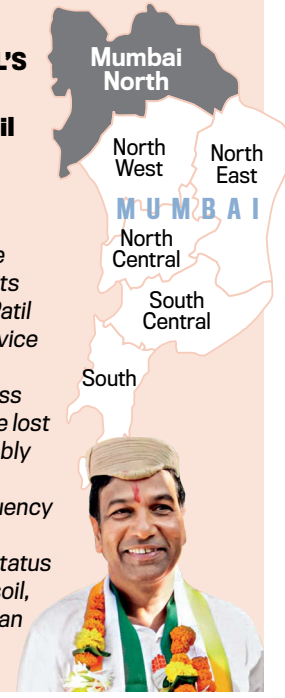
2019		2014
Winner Gopal Shetty BJP		Winner Gopal Shetty BJP
71	Vote share (%)	70
24		23
Runner-up Urmila Matondkar Congress		Runner-up Sanjay Nirupam Congress

Rest: others; figures have been rounded off

PIYUSH GOYAL'S CHALLENGER

Bhushan Patil
Congress

Rising through the party ranks, starting with the National Students Union of India, Patil is currently the vice president of the Mumbai Congress unit. Although he lost the state assembly election in the Borivali constituency in 2009, Patil is banking on his status as a son of the soil, fighting against an "outsider"



on how connectivity to his constituency would vastly improve once the Rs 6,500 crore tunnel linking Mumbai with Thane comes up, passing under the Sanjay Gandhi National Park and cutting the commute time to Marine Drive by more than an hour. He also briefs residents about the medical facilities he would bring, with the construction of a 1,000-bed hospital by a charitable trust so that they don't have to travel to Central Mumbai for emergencies. Later, addressing slum dwellers, Goyal told them he will ensure that each of them gets pucca houses in the same area as part of the redevelopment plan under the Modi Ki Guarantee schemes. He also promised that drainage works would be complete.

Though Mumbai North has been the BJP's citadel for over three decades, Goyal will have to battle the tag of being an "outsider candidate" and the linguistic divide between Marathi speakers and non-Maharashtrians as he takes on his challenger—Bhushan Patil of the Congress. Unlike the incumbent two-term MP Gopal Shetty who has been dropped, Goyal lacks the local connect with workers and voters. A former corporator and Mumbai deputy mayor before he was elected the MLA from Borivali, Shetty is known among his supporters as a "garden samrat" for developing around 10 gardens across the constituency. He is also known for his brand of "instant justice" and has a pan-community and pan-linguistic appeal given his fluency in Marathi, Hindi, Gujarati and Kannada. The BJP has dropped Shetty to nominate Goyal in what is seen as one of the safest seats for the party across India.

BJP insiders say Shetty was upset at being ousted from the constituency he had nurtured, but that hasn't stopped him from extending Goyal unconditional support; he is a constant companion on his election rath. Goyal's constituency also has a diverse social spread—from the tribal *pada*s or hamlets in the Sanjay Gandhi National Park, Mumbai's largest green lung, to the *koliwada*s or fishing villages at Gorai and Bhati, gleaming glass-chrome IT hubs in Malad, and slums in Kurar. "Our victory is certain," Atul Bhatkhalkar, the BJP MLA from Kandivali East, says. "The only issue is people want Modi as the prime minister." BJP leader Kishor Joshi says Mumbai North stood to benefit if it elected a Union minister to the Lok Sabha. "He will use his influence as a senior leader to solve several issues and get new projects into the constituency," he points out.

UNLIKE SITTING MP GOPAL SHETTY WHO HAS BEEN DROPPED, GOYAL HAS TO BATTLE THE TAG OF BEING AN 'OUTSIDER' WHILE WOOING THE VOTERS

However, BJP leaders concede that the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) is likely to give the battle a Marathi vs non-Marathi colour as the Congress nominee Patil is a Maharashtrian and belongs to the Aagri community, regarded as among Mumbai's original settlers, along with groups like Kolis and Bhandaris. "The only saving grace for us is that the Congress does not have an image as a pro-Marathi party," says a BJP functionary. However, Aslam Shaikh, a former minister and the Congress MLA from Malad West, claims their chances are bright and points to how his party won the seat in 2004 and 2009. Now, with the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) led by former chief minister Uddhav Thackeray in alliance with the Congress as part of the larger MVA, Patil is expected to get a chunk of the Marathi vote.

Goyal has also found himself in the thick of several controversies, especially the one after students at the Thakur College of Science and Commerce in Kandivali, which is part of his Lok Sabha constituency, were allegedly forced to attend the speech of his son Dhruv Goyal in March. The IDs of the students were reportedly confiscated to ensure they were present when he spoke. In April, Neha Purav, a journalist with a vernacular daily, who had reported on Goyal's apparent discomfort with the smell of fish (he is said to have covered his nose with a handkerchief while campaigning in the *gaothan*s or village settlements in his constituency), filed a complaint with the police after unknown individuals allegedly threatened her. None of these controversies has dented Goyal's confidence of not only winning North Mumbai handsomely but also the BJP and its allies getting more than the 41 seats the NDA won in 2019. His reason? "It is Modi all the way—there is no other issue. The biggest issue is trust and when we say '*Modi hai to mumkin hai*', it comes out of the fact that whatever he says, he delivers." Goyal may have grown up in South Mumbai but he is certainly going north in the city in 2024. ■